

Lab: Pattern Design Workshop — Pattern Languages as Shared Code

Objective

Experience the challenges and strategies of communicating crochet patterns across different encoding systems, terminology conventions, and media formats.

Materials Needed

- A simple crochet pattern in US terms
- Access to a US/UK terminology conversion chart
- Graph paper (for charting)
- A partner from your crochet circle
- Hook and yarn for a small swatch

Exercise 1: The Translation Challenge (30 minutes)

Take your US-term pattern and translate it into: 1. UK terms (replace all US abbreviations with UK equivalents) 2. A stitch chart on graph paper (one cell per stitch, using standard symbols)

Then give all three versions (US written, UK written, chart) to three different partners. Have each person read their version and describe what they think the finished piece will look like.

Compare: Did all three encoding methods produce the same mental image? Where did communication break down?

Exercise 2: The Ambiguity Audit (20 minutes)

Choose a pattern and read through it with "beginner eyes." Flag every instruction that: - Uses an abbreviation without defining it - Assumes prior knowledge (e.g., "work in the round")

without explaining how to join) - Could be interpreted in more than one way - Lacks a stitch count verification point

Count the flags. The total is an estimate of how much of the generative model the pattern fails to encode — the gap that the reader's own model must fill.

Exercise 3: The Telephone Game (30 minutes)

1. Crocheter A makes a simple swatch (5 rows, 15 stitches, using 2-3 stitch types)
2. Crocheter A writes instructions for the swatch (without showing it to anyone)
3. Crocheter B reads the instructions and makes the swatch
4. Compare the two swatches

Discuss: Where did the communication succeed? Where did it fail? What was lost in the encoding/decoding process?

Exercise 4: Platform Feedback Analysis (20 minutes)

If you have access to Ravelry or another pattern platform, choose a popular pattern and read 15-20 project notes. Categorize the feedback:

Category	Count	Example
Confirmed predictions (pattern worked as expected)		
Prediction errors (sizing off, gauge issues)		
Encoding problems (confusing instructions)		
Modifications shared		
Questions asking for clarification		

Reflect: What does this feedback reveal about the quality of the pattern as a communicated generative model?

Discussion Questions for the Circle

1. Do you prefer US terms, UK terms, charts, or video tutorials? What does your preference tell you about how your cognitive model processes information?
2. Have you ever been confused by a pattern's terminology? How did you resolve the confusion?
3. If you have used patterns from international designers (Japanese, Portuguese, etc.), what communication challenges did you encounter?

Wrap-Up

Write a brief reflection (3-5 sentences) on the challenges of communicating a generative model through a crochet pattern. What makes some patterns excellent communicators and others confusing?